

Passage 1

Read the text and answer questions 1–13.

Transport and Transport Systems During the Roman Empire

How Rome moved people, goods, and information across an empire

At the height of the Roman Empire in the 2nd century AD, it was not uncommon for Romans to travel long distances by road across Europe and beyond. In fact, it was actually quite easy to travel, thanks to the empire's highly developed road and shipping networks. It has been calculated that Roman roads covered a total distance of over 400,000 kilometres, with more than 120,000 kilometres of this being of the type known as 'public roads' and a second system classified as 'military roads', both constructed by soldiers. The roads spread across the empire from Britain in the north to Morocco in the south, from Portugal in the west to Iraq in the east. Roads played a crucial role in the maintenance of the empire, allowing people and goods to move relatively swiftly. Tolls were charged for the use of many major roads, with stations where these tolls were paid often situated at bridges or at city gates.

Roman roads were famously durable and straight. Engineers began by digging a trench along the planned route, which was then filled with layers of stone, gravel, and cement. The top surface was made of large, flat paving stones fitted tightly together. Roads were slightly raised in the centre to allow rainwater to drain off into side ditches. Because of this careful construction, many Roman roads remained usable for centuries after the fall of the empire – some are still in use today. The famous saying 'All roads lead to Rome' was not merely a proverb but a literal reality: the Romans designed their road network so that major routes converged on the capital, facilitating central control and rapid deployment of the army.

Transport by sea was equally important. The Mediterranean Sea, which the Romans called *Mare Nostrum* ('Our Sea'), served as a highway connecting the empire's most prosperous provinces. Sea travel was far cheaper than land transport: moving goods by ship cost approximately one-tenth of the price of moving them the same distance by road. Consequently, bulky commodities such as grain, olive oil, wine, and building materials were typically shipped by sea whenever possible. Rome itself depended heavily on grain imports from Egypt and North Africa, which arrived via massive cargo vessels that could carry up to 1,000 tonnes of produce. The main hazards of sea travel were piracy, storms, and poor navigation, though the Roman navy eventually suppressed most piracy in the Mediterranean.

For official travel and military communications, the Romans developed a sophisticated courier system known as the *cursus publicus* (public course). Established by Emperor Augustus, this system used relays of horses and riders stationed at intervals of approximately 8 to 12 kilometres along major roads. Official messengers could cover up to 80 kilometres per day on foot or 160 kilometres per day on horseback, and urgent messages could be delivered even faster using a system of fresh horses at each station. Use of the *cursus publicus* was restricted to government officials and military personnel. Private citizens had to rely on slower, privately operated transport or join informal caravans for longer journeys.

Despite the efficiency of Roman transport, travel was not without difficulty. Road travel could be uncomfortable: wheeled vehicles had no suspension, and passengers felt every bump in the road. Most people travelled on foot or by mule, while the wealthy might ride in a covered carriage (raeda) or be carried in a litter (lectica) by slaves. Inns along the roadside had a notoriously bad reputation for dirt, bedbugs, and sometimes even dishonest innkeepers who robbed or murdered guests. Wealthier travellers often preferred to stay in private villas owned by friends or acquaintances, relying on a network of mutual hospitality among the elite.

The decline of the Roman Empire from the 3rd century AD onwards led to the gradual deterioration of its transport networks. Reduced trade, military threats, and falling tax revenues meant that roads and bridges were no longer maintained. Many fell into disrepair or were deliberately broken up for building materials. It was not until the construction of modern highways in the 18th and 19th centuries that Europe would again see a road system as extensive and well-engineered as that of the Romans.

Questions 1–5

Do the following statements agree with the information given in Reading Passage 1?

TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 1 All Roman roads were built by soldiers.
- 2 Roman roads were designed to allow water to drain off the surface.
- 3 Sea transport was approximately ten times cheaper than land transport.
- 4 The cursus publicus was available to all Roman citizens without restriction.
- 5 Wealthy Romans sometimes stayed in private homes instead of inns when travelling.

Questions 6–9

Complete the sentences below.

Choose **NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS** from the passage for each answer.

6. In addition to public roads, the Romans also built a network of
7. Tolls were often collected at bridges or
8. The Romans called the Mediterranean Sea , meaning 'Our Sea'.
9. The largest Roman cargo vessels could transport up to of goods.

Questions 10–13

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C, or D.

10. What does the author say about the saying 'All roads lead to Rome'?

- A) It was only a myth with no basis in reality.
- B) It reflected the design of the Roman road network.
- C) It was invented by modern historians.
- D) It referred only to roads in Italy.

11. According to the passage, what was the main reason for shipping grain by sea?

- A) Sea travel was faster than land travel.
- B) The Roman navy provided free transport.
- C) Moving large quantities by sea was much cheaper.
- D) Grain could not be transported over land.

12. What was the maximum distance an official messenger on horseback could cover per day using the cursus publicus?

- A) 8 kilometres
- B) 12 kilometres
- C) 80 kilometres
- D) 160 kilometres

13. Why did Roman transport networks eventually decline?

- A) The Romans discovered faster methods of travel.
- B) Roads were intentionally destroyed by foreign invaders.
- C) The empire faced economic and military difficulties.
- D) Citizens preferred to travel on foot rather than by road.

Answers

- 1 TRUE
- 2 TRUE
- 3 TRUE
- 4 FALSE
- 5 TRUE
- 6 military roads
- 7 city gates
- 8 Mare Nostrum
- 9 1000 TONNES
- 10 B
- 11 C
- 12 D
- 13 C